one such exercise, as soon as taking office, he had directed some senior-most officers in the Indian government to take time out to visit the place where they first started service. He had insisted that they take their family along if it was possible. He had urged them to ask themselves, ‘What is the condition of the place where I first started duty?’ Many officers returned disappointed in the growth of that place. The exercise turned out to be an eye-opener. The prime minister had then explained to them, ‘You see how little your service has contributed to the overall growth of that place? We must work together as a unit towards common goals for the nation, to bring in maximum progress.’

Just as he did then, even now he needed to find a solution that could cut bureaucratic red tape, thus improving government response time once again. He thought about solutions which may have been explored in the past. In time of such an emergency which was impacting millions of lives worldwide and was poised to hit India like an avalanche, a well-planned and coordinated emergency response strategy was key. The challenges which would confront the government on a daily basis were going to be new and their magnitude and gravity would be severe. In order to confront these, the solutions would also have to be innovative and there would be a desperate need to augment and synchronize efforts by cutting across ministries and departments. We would need to create ‘empowered groups’ on each major challenge, which would constitute a mix of subject-matter experts and highly ranked government officers. As the name suggests, these groups would be empowered to delineate policy, formulate plans, strategize operations and take all necessary steps for effective and time-bound implementation of these decisions in their respective areas. Details of the breakdown of empowered groups and their constitution was then mulled over with the scientists and other officers in the PMO, after which the home secretary in his capacity as chairperson of the National Executive Committee and the powers vested in him under the Section 10(2)(h) and (i) of the Disaster Management Act, would have to issue the official order to constitute such groups.

In addition to all this, the prime minister was also receiving simultaneous feedback from his own network of individuals he had cultivated over decades of public service. This was his distinct working style—he was adept at gathering information on a certain matter from multiple sources, only after which he would make a decision, thus